

Week 8: Design Patterns in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Bible stories separated by centuries sometimes echo each other on purpose — tonight we'll look at how to start spotting those connections.

1. Have you ever noticed a movie or show deliberately echo an earlier scene — the same shot, the same line, the same choice — to make a point by comparison? What did that repetition make you think or feel?
2. The video traced one pattern — *see it, want it, take it* — from Eve through Aaron's golden calf to David. **Read Genesis 4:1-16**, the very next story after Eden. What does God say to Cain in verses 9-12 that he has already said, almost word for word, in Genesis 3? What is the author signaling by making the second story rhyme this closely with the first?
3. **Read Joshua 7:1, then 7:19-26.** Centuries later, an Israelite named Achan is caught. Read his confession in verse 21 — "I saw... I coveted... I took... hidden in my tent." How many earlier stories is that one sentence built to echo? What does it change about a story to realize it was written to rhyme with others?
4. This pattern turns up with completely different people — a couple in a garden, a priest at a mountain, a king on a roof, a soldier with stolen loot — spread across more than a thousand years. And the serpent from Genesis 3 never appears again. What are the biblical authors saying about human nature by building the same shape into story after story?
5. **Read Luke 3:21-22 and 4:1-13** (and glance at the last line of the genealogy in between, 3:38). Here's a different kind of design pattern — one author, one repeated phrase. Luke lines up scene after scene that each turn on "Son of God": the voice at the baptism, the genealogy ending "...the son of Adam, the son of God," then Satan's "if you are the Son of God." What is Luke getting you to do by circling the same title from several angles instead of just stating it once?

6. In Gethsemane, facing his own great temptation, Jesus says "not my will, but yours be done" — the first time in the whole story someone meets that moment and doesn't take. You've seen this from the video. Push further: why does it matter that the pattern finally breaks through surrender and suffering rather than through Jesus getting what he wanted?
7. Once you're looking for patterns, it gets tempting to "find" them everywhere — Tim Mackie admits this is the real risk of reading the Bible this way. What do you think separates a connection the author built on purpose from one a reader imagined?
8. Where do you see the "see it, want it, take it" pattern running in your own life, or in the temptations you face most often?
9. Knowing how deliberately these patterns were woven across dozens of books and centuries, how does that shape the way you think about the Bible — as one coordinated story rather than a loose anthology?